Charting mere catholicity: the historic communions

What has been believed everywhere, always, and by all.
Rome, the Orthodox of the East and the Orient, and the confessional churches of the Reformation, graded row by row from their own binding standards against the faith the whole Church received.
The charting papers, part one of three.

Continue to part two: the free churches.

The chart below sorts the dogmas the whole Church has received from the claims she has not. Where does that list of received dogmas come from, and why does it stop? The rule is older than the divisions that made this chart necessary. In the year 434, before Chalcedon, before the Great Schism, centuries before the Reformation, a monk of the island of Lérins named St. Vincent wrote down the test the Church already lived by: hold **what has been believed everywhere, always, and by all**. That is the line at the head of this page, and it is a working tool, not a slogan. Each of the three words is a knife. **Everywhere** cuts away whatever was only regional, one country's custom, one see's usage. **Always** cuts away whatever arrived later, however venerable the century that added it. **By all** cuts away the positions of parties and schools, and even the private opinions of the greatest saints, for no single doctor is the measure, the consensus is. Put the whole of Christian teaching to those three knives and most of it falls away. What survives all three is the catholic core, and it is small on purpose.

And St. Vincent's rule does not work alone, for the Church has organs to apply it. The seven ecumenical councils are where the whole Church spoke, gathered from East and West to define the faith against error. The consensus of the Fathers is where her teachers agree across centuries, languages, and continents, no one of them the measure alone. And the sensus fidelium is the instinct of the whole baptized people, who were praying to Christ as God and reading the Scriptures as canon before any council said so. The three witnesses check one another. A council defines, the Fathers show the definition was the faith already held, and the people receive it into their worship, and where all three agree the teaching is authoritative. That agreement is what the chart's green marks are made of.

And where does Scripture stand in this? Above everything, as the supreme witness of the faith, God-breathed and clear in the things necessary for salvation, read within the Church that received it and not against her. Scripture is also the proof that reception needs no infallible referee. Rome objects that without a living court to settle every question, nothing is ever settled. But ask how the Church got her Bible. No pope and no council of the undivided age ever closed the canon of Scripture by decree. The Church received it core first and edges slowly, the Gospels and Paul held everywhere from the beginning, the disputed edges tolerated for centuries, and East and West differ at the margins still. If reception without a referee were not enough, there would be no Bible to argue from. Meanwhile the court that claims to be the bedrock has reversed its own teaching in both directions, and a bedrock cannot do that. The bedrock is not a court. It is the living God, whose will is made known in His Word and borne by His whole Church in the life of the Holy Spirit.

The same knives answer the question an honest reader asks next, why the received dogmas fill nine rows and not ninety. Ancient practice alone does not qualify, for the Church distinguishes her disciplines from her deposit. Fasting rules, calendars, clerical celibacy, leavened or unleavened bread, all real, all old, and none of it confessed as the faith itself. Majority opinion does not qualify, only consensus does, which is why the counting of the sacraments, numbered differently by holy men across the centuries, is held lightly rather than charted. And what is already inside a row does not get a second row, so the Trinity is not listed apart, for the Creed confesses it. What is ancient and precious but belongs to practice rather than dogma, the Psalter, the fasts, the sign of the cross, is mapped on Lex orandi, this chart's companion in prayer. The core is short because the rule is strict. What was believed everywhere, always, and by all is a small thing and a sufficient one, a firm center with an honest margin, which is what the Church has always in fact had. St. Vincent's rule is kept whole in his Commonitory, and the Credo confesses the core clause by clause.

A council binds when the whole body of believers comes to confess it, so the received rows are the faith that already binds all Christians, and the set-down rows stand as each part's own teaching, not yet received by the whole and not a condition any part may exact of the rest.

✓ confessed in the communion's binding standards.
? substance affirmed while mode or formula stands open, or the question itself not yet closed.
╳ not confessed in the standards as they stand, and nothing more. It does not mean do not worship there. It means the man who holds the whole first millennium in that communion will need an exception or two to his confession's paper, and a man may confess more than his standard. And the mark reverses its meaning across the chart. Among the received rows a red X marks a gap between a communion's paper and the received faith. Among the set-down rows it marks only what that communion never bound alone, which is no fault at all. No mark on this chart puts anyone out of the Body of Christ, and the notes carry the argument the glyphs cannot.
The chart grades confessions, not Christians. Every column baptizes into the one Body, and every red X among the received rows is healable by the hand that set it. Each column's case follows the chart.

History gives every ╳ among the received rows hope. The Church of the East refused the council of Ephesus, and the churches of Egypt, Armenia, and Syria refused Chalcedon, yet each confessed all along, in its own words, the very faith those councils defended, and the agreed statements of our own day record the match. The refusals stayed on paper while the faith itself was received. Reception can close a gap from both sides, and it has done so before. What that hope asks of each communion, the cases below say by name.

	The faith confessed	Roman Catholic	Eastern Orthodox	Oriental Orthodox	Assyrian	High Anglican	Confessional Lutheran	Presbyterian
Received by the whole Church in the first millennium								

	The faith confessed	Roman Catholic	Eastern Orthodox	Oriental Orthodox	Assyrian	High Anglican	Confessional Lutheran	Presbyterian
Catholicity together	The Holy Scriptures	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	The Nicene Creed	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	The christology of the seven councils	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Mary the Theotokos, Mother of God (Ephesus)	✓	✓	✓	?§	✓	✓	?§
	The veneration of the holy icons (Nicaea II)	✓	✓	✓	?***	✓***	?***	?***
	The apostolic succession of bishops	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓†	?*	?*
	The real presence in the Eucharist (corporeal)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	?**
	The regeneration given in Baptism	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	?§§
	The moral consensus of the Fathers (life, marriage, holy orders) ‡	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Set down, not thrown away, awaiting reception

The faith confessed	Roman Catholic	Eastern Orthodox	Oriental Orthodox	Assyrian	High Anglican	Confessional Lutheran	Presbyterian
Defined since the schisms by one part of the divided Church, and so not yet received by the whole							
Papal infallibility, Vatican I (1870)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
The Marian definitions (1854 and 1950)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Trent's anathemas on justification (1547)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
The Palamite councils (1341 to 1351)	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
The Thirty-Nine Articles as binding (1571) ††	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
The Augsburg Confession as binding (1530)	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓	✗
The Westminster Standards as binding (1646)	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓

> * Their pastors are ordained by presbyters rather than bishops, and whether presbyteral succession preserves the ministry is a real question, worked out in The bishop and the presbyter. The book records both readings, walks the narrower in its own map, and does not close the question.

† Claimed and maintained in the historic line, and contested. Rome denied these orders in 1896, by an act the book declines to treat as final, and the question stands open, healable by the party that raised it. The book grades these altars contested rather than settled.

** On the presence the row asks the corporeal confession, and the Reformed standards give a divided answer, which is what the question mark records. Westminster's own words affirm the substance: worthy receivers really and indeed, yet not carnally and corporally but spiritually, receive and feed upon Christ crucified, the body and blood of Christ being as really, but spiritually, present to the faith of believers as the elements themselves are to their outward senses (Westminster Confession 29). A true feeding on the true body and blood, confessed. What the confession refuses is the corporeal mode, the elements remaining bread and wine, and whether that refusal reaches the confessed thing itself or only one description of it is precisely the question the mark leaves open, for the tradition's own doctors answered it both ways. Princeton read the confession down, Hodge's presence of virtue and effect, and it was Princeton's lower reading the churches largely followed. But Calvin himself sits green on this row by his own words, "we are truly made partakers of the proper substance of the body and blood of Jesus Christ" (Short Treatise on the Lord's Supper, 1541), and Nevin's Mystical Presence of 1846 argued that the original Reformed doctrine was "a real communication with his substantial, personal, mediatorial life." The school has a name, Mercersburg theology, from the seminary where Nevin and Philip Schaff taught, called by its friends high church Presbyterianism or sacramental Calvinism, in our day Reformed catholicity, and scholars now grant that Nevin had the history right. The confessional high-water marks agree with him: the Belgic Confession calls what we eat and drink "the true, natural body and the true blood of Christ," and the Scots Confession of 1560 utterly damns those who say the sacraments are naked and bare signs. So the cell is read with both readings on the table: with Hodge it would be red, with Calvin it would be green, and the standards as they stand bind neither, which is the question mark's exact meaning in this chart's legend. The direction of travel is the good news, for the recovery of Calvin's own doctrine is the living school in these churches, and a tradition walking back toward its founder is walking toward this row's green. What would settle it is plain: chapter 29 read, taught, and in time amended by the tradition's own oldest stratum, Calvin, the Belgic, and the Scots, the church healing itself from its own beginnings, as the American church amended Westminster's own chapters on the civil magistrate in 1788 and subscribes the amended text to this day, and an agreed statement recording the match, as 1994 recorded one for the East. The High Anglican check on this row is graded, as the icons note's is, from the Affirmation of St. Louis, which receives the presence with the councils and reads the Articles as witness beneath them.

§§ The Reformed standards do not deny the grace of Baptism but untie it from the moment of the act. The grace promised is really exhibited and conferred by the Holy Ghost in God's appointed time (Westminster Confession 28.6), and what is refused is the binding of the gift to the minute of the washing. A grace affirmed but untied is a question, not a refusal.

*** Not iconoclasm on every hand. The Lutheran churches kept the image and the crucifix against the image-breakers, and condemn nothing here. What they do not confess is the seventh council's definition, that the honor given the image passes to its prototype, and the veneration it commands. The book faces the same problem with the Assyrian Church of the East, which uses almost no images at all, and it still places their altars in the first tier, because they venerate the cross and do not condemn what they do not practice. The parallel reaches the Lutheran. The Reformed standards go further and condemn the use itself, and the Presbyterian mark is a question by the tradition's own courts. The catechism's paper condemns the making of any image of Christ (Larger Catechism 109), and the strict school that defends that reading whole is honored as serious men reading their own words plainly. But the standard as actually subscribed is more open than its page, for the exception touching images of Christ used for teaching stands among the most commonly taken and granted in the

presbyteries’ own records, and households keep the children’s Bible under the catechism that forbids it, so what the standard finally binds is a question the tradition itself has not closed, which is this chart’s own definition of the mark. Let the generosity be stated plainly, and its limit with it. The mark is not a check and cannot be, for the row is the veneration the whole Church received at Nicaea II, and veneration is practiced by no one here, so not even practice offers a check. And the ask was never veneration. The Assyrian column stands in the first tier with aniconic altars, venerating the cross and condemning nothing, so the whole distance from this question mark to peace is the end of the condemnation, a step the exception-granting courts have half taken already. The mark is set at its generous reading, in hope, and the hope is specific: the catechism’s condemnation amended by the same pen that amended 1788, after which this cell rests as the Assyrian’s does, condemning nothing and required to venerate nothing. The High Anglican check rests on the Continuing churches' Affirmation of St. Louis, which receives the seven councils entire, against the plain sense of Article 22 elsewhere.

§ The Assyrian Church long avoided the title, fearing it divided Christ, and the Common Declaration of 1994 recognized that her own Mother of Christ our God and Saviour confesses the same faith. The formula differs, the faith is received, which is this chart's whole method in one cell. The Westminster standards entail the doctrine, of the substance of the Virgin Mary, but never use the title.

‡ Plainly: life means the ancient witness against abortion and euthanasia, held from the Didache on. Marriage means marriage as the whole Church received it, the union of a man and a woman, and no blessing of sodomy. Holy orders means ordination as the whole Church knew it, reserved to men. This row is why the columns are the conservative wings and not the mainlines. The book makes it a second sorting condition beside the marks, and it is the row on which the Union of Utrecht, which keeps the succession five for five and ordains women, falls off this chart entirely. Orders alone do not carry the deposit.

†† The X runs the whole row, and the Anglican X is the interesting one. The Continuing churches, by the Affirmation of St. Louis, receive the Articles as a historical witness subordinate to the seven councils, not as a binding confession, which makes the High Anglican the one communion on this chart that already holds its own confessional document as patrimony rather than condition, the very act the book asks of every other column. Said with care: the old Church of England bound her clergy to the Articles by subscription, so the X marks the High Anglican as he stands on this chart, not as he stood in 1571.

What catholicity asks of each communion

The Roman Catholic case. What catholicity asks of him is a setting down, of papal infallibility as Vatican I defined it, of the Marian definitions of 1854 and 1950 as binding dogma, of the finality of Trent's anathemas on justification, and a retiring, of the claim that the Roman communion alone is the one true Church, the same claim the East is asked to retire of herself. Set down means set down for him too. He withholds the assent of faith as the Presbyterian officer takes his exception. What the book then asks of Rome herself is the corporate form of the same act, to hold these definitions as her own patrimony, awaiting reception by the whole, acknowledging they are not held by all, and demanding them of no one as a condition of communion, her own son who has set them down included. And the claim to be alone the one true Church is not patrimony to keep but a claim to retire, by Rome and by the East alike. This is dissent toward catholicity, not away from it, disciplined and principled, not renegade. He prays for the Bishop of Rome by name, gives him the obedience the first millennium gave, filial and real but not absolute, makes no faction, and appeals from within. His case is harder than the Presbyterian's, for Rome's present law licenses no exceptions and calls this dissent. He approaches the altar anyway, a son appealing to the whole Body's future reception, standing at her altar without claiming she blesses it, and he bears what may follow without resentment, holding his exceptions for the unity of the whole. That is how catholicity is held in the Roman communion.

The Eastern Orthodox case. His column is green down the received rows, every one, so nothing is asked of his faith. Catholicity asks him to set down the Palamite councils as binding on all, holding them as the East's own patrimony until the whole receives them, and to retire the claim that Orthodoxy alone is the one true Church, which is not a definition awaiting the whole but a claim against it. His discipline is the mirror of the Roman one, make no faction, and let the appeal be lived rather than shouted in his own house. And his advantage is real, and this page owes him the debt said plainly. The Eastern doctrine of reception, that the guardian of the faith is the whole body of the Church, the people themselves, as the Eastern Patriarchs answered Rome in 1848, is the very cure this chart prescribes, widened, for the Encyclical meant by the whole Church her own communion, and the book means the whole divided Body. The medicine and the overdose came in one bottle, and she is asked to keep the medicine and set down the overdose. And one work is asked beyond the setting down, the third profession's live labor, the recognition his communion does not yet extend to the Oriental churches, whose case stands beside his. That is how catholicity is held in the Orthodox communion.

The Oriental Orthodox case. His column is green down the received rows, and his communion is the page's proof rather than its pupil. His fathers refused Chalcedon's formula fearing it divided Christ, confessed the guarded faith in their own words for fifteen centuries, and the agreed statements of our own day record the match, the whole method of this chart demonstrated at scale. So nothing is asked of his faith. What is asked is the live work the book calls the third profession, that his communion and the Eastern Orthodox extend to one another the recognition their common declarations already support, for between those two houses it is not yet in force. And one admission is owed him. The book holds his place as it holds every judgment it makes, provisionally and in hope, on the first-millennium evidence and not as a verdict already in. That is how catholicity is held in the Oriental communion, and it has been held there through fifteen centuries of patience.

The Assyrian case. His is the oldest tear on the chart and the smallest communion, and the least is asked of him, because his church already did what this page proposes. She refused the council of Ephesus and confessed the one Christ it defended, in Babai her doctor and in her liturgy, and in 1994 Rome and the Church of the East signed the declaration recording that the faith was one while the formulas differed, the very kind of act the book's proposal multiplies. Her aniconic altars stand in the first tier because she venerates the cross and condemns nothing she does not practice, the door this page keeps pointing the Presbyterian toward. What remains is to carry the recognition of 1994 through with the other ancient communions. That is how catholicity is held in the Assyrian communion, and it has been held there longer than anywhere else, with the least said about it.

The High Anglican case. His is the shortest case on the page, for his column runs green down the received rows and claims nothing alone beneath them. The Continuing churches already hold the Articles as historical witness rather than binding condition, which is the very act this chart asks of every other column, performed already, in 1977. So nothing is asked of his faith and nothing of his paper. His burdens are two, and neither is assent. His orders lie under the doubt of 1896,[†] which only the party that raised it can heal, and his provinces divide over the very moral consensus this chart stakes, so his task is to hold the confession entire and to be, where he stands, the proof that it can be kept. That is how catholicity is held in the Anglican communion.

The Confessional Lutheran case. His sacraments are already green, the presence confessed without qualification and the grace of Baptism with it, and on the holy icons[***] he keeps the image, condemns nothing, and stands a step from the Assyrian door. What catholicity asks of him is two things. On the ministry[*] he is asked to press his communion back toward the episcopate the first millennium knew, owed on either reading, the question the bishop and presbyter paper leaves open. And on Augsburg he is asked what Rome and the East are asked, to hold his confession as patrimony rather than exact it, which his own tradition half remembers, for Augsburg was written as an appeal within the one Church, not as the charter of another. That is how catholicity is held in the Lutheran communion.

The Presbyterian case. The layman takes no subscription vow at all, only his officers do, for his membership vows ask a credible profession of Christ, not the Standards, which is his own polity's design. So from the pew he may confess the whole first millennium without asking anyone's leave. He may hold the regeneration given in Baptism[§§] on his standard's own words. It is his ministers who must take exception to Westminster's chapter 29 to confess the presence in the gifts themselves,[**] siding, ironically, with Calvin himself and the Mercersburg school of high church Presbyterianism against Princeton's lower reading, and his courts may refuse it, which is why the presence note says the paper itself needs mending. And his own confession agrees, for Westminster teaches that all synods and councils may err and many have, so to hold the Standards as reformable is not to hold them loosely but to hold them on their own terms. And on the holy icons[***] the Presbyterian road is the Assyrian one, an exception to Larger Catechism 109 that ceases to condemn the veneration Presbyterians do not practice, the very posture that keeps the aniconic Assyrian altars in the first tier. And on the ministry[*] he is asked to press his communion back toward the episcopate the first millennium knew, owed on either reading, the question the bishop and presbyter paper leaves open. That is how catholicity is held in the Presbyterian communion. And the asking is mutual. Rome is asked to walk back her solo definitions, the East hers, and the Presbyterian is asked to out-confess his own paper, each part holding catholicity together from its own side.

The chart's columns end at Westminster, and most American Christians worship past its edge. The same nine rows measure them too, and the same rule, read the other way: where the older communions are asked to set down, the younger churches are asked to pick up. Part two, charting the free churches, is that page.

The end sought is not ecclesiological tidiness. It is the Lord's high priestly prayer, that they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me (John 17:21).

Continue to part two: the free churches.

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.